Siegfried Lorenz. Schabowski worked to gauge which party members needed convincing to support the plan. ‘It wasn’t possible to topple Honecker by a military putsch,’ he later explained. ‘It was only possible in the politburo. We wanted to make it appear that he [Honecker] had resigned.’17 The hardest of all to suborn was Schalck-Golodkowski, the currency guru, who eventually pledged support.18 At that moment, Krenz dispatched Harry Tisch, the powerful trade union boss to inform Gorbachev of the conspiracy. ‘He [Gorbachev] welcomed the fact,’ Tisch recounted. ‘Gorbachev realised we had reached the point where we understood that life had caught up with us.’19

Throughout this period, the Americans, unsurprisingly, took a perhaps closer than usual interest in events. US Ambassador Richard C. Barkley recalled:

After the fact, we realised that the system really demanded someone like Honecker around to make the big decisions. So, for the longest period of time, a lot of the key decisions were postponed. So, at a time when there were great shifts throughout Eastern Europe, there was nobody in East Berlin to give guidance.

Whether they were right or wrong, people knew what was expected of them. But even political instruments like Neues Deutschland didn’t know what to do. The usual policy among the East Germans if there is foreign news that you didn’t want to talk about, you didn’t print it. For example, during that period of time, there was no reporting about the elections in Poland that brought Walesa to power. There was no talk about Tiananmen Square in Beijing. The discussions that were going on in the paper were about how to handle the outflow of tourists, which was increasing daily. It was the summertime after all. That is when people went on holiday. So, they were not addressing a lot of these problems. So, they were in some respects put into a box, at a particularly perfect time for those who were against the regime, or who wanted to get out.